

Foot and Ankle Arthritis: Symptoms, Exercises and Footwear

Complete UK guide to foot and ankle arthritis. Symptoms, exercises, best shoes, orthotics and NHS treatment options for managing joint pain in your feet.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-01-20 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk



*Warm foot soak with herbs for arthritis pain relief in a cosy bathroom setting
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Your feet contain **33 joints each**, making them particularly vulnerable to arthritis. Foot and ankle arthritis affects millions of people across the UK, causing pain with every step and significantly impacting mobility and quality of life. Whether you have osteoarthritis in the big toe, rheumatoid arthritis affecting multiple foot joints, or post-traumatic arthritis following an ankle injury, understanding your condition and knowing the right management strategies can make an enormous difference. This guide covers symptoms, exercises, footwear choices and NHS treatment pathways.

Common Types of Foot Arthritis

Big Toe Arthritis (Hallux Rigidus)

The most common site for foot osteoarthritis. The big toe joint becomes stiff and painful, particularly when pushing off during walking. You may notice a bony bump on top of the joint and difficulty wearing certain shoes. It affects approximately 2.5% of people over 50 in the UK.

Midfoot Arthritis

Affects the joints in the middle of the foot, causing a deep aching pain across the top of the foot that worsens with walking on uneven surfaces. Often develops after previous injury or gradually with age.

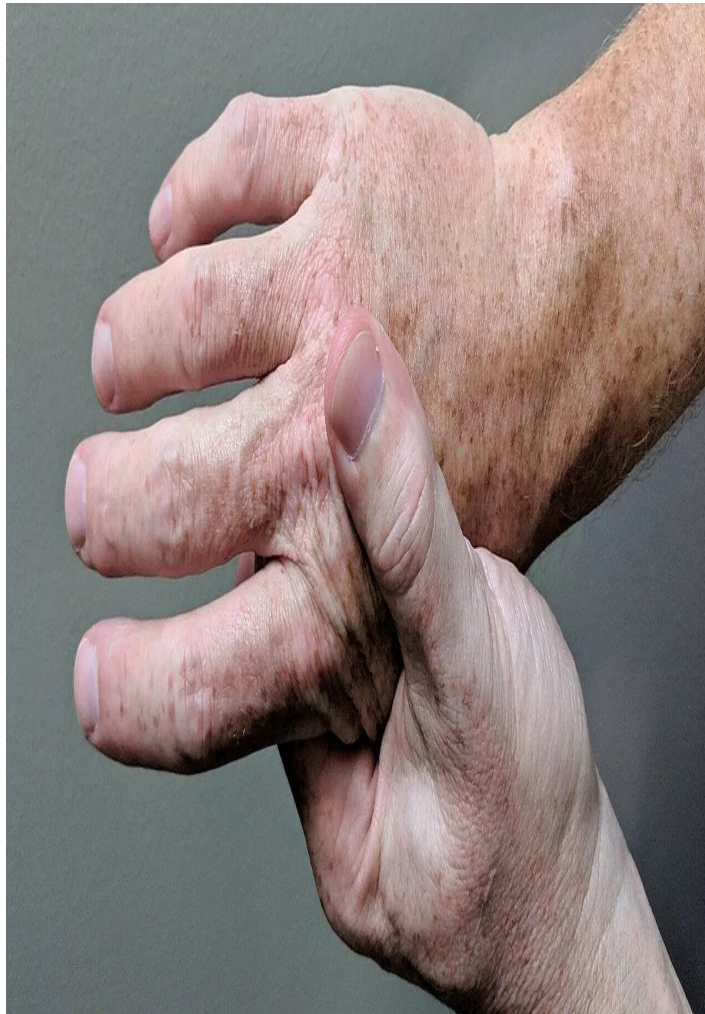
Ankle Arthritis

Less common than knee or hip arthritis but can be severely disabling. Most ankle arthritis is post-traumatic — following previous fractures, severe sprains or ligament injuries. Symptoms include deep ankle pain, stiffness (especially in the morning), swelling and difficulty on uneven ground.

Rheumatoid Arthritis of the Feet

RA frequently affects the feet — up to **90% of RA patients** develop foot problems during their disease course. RA typically affects the small joints of the toes (metatarsophalangeal joints), causing pain under the ball of the foot, toe deformities (hammer toes, claw toes) and difficulty finding comfortable footwear.

Exercises for Foot and Ankle Arthritis



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Regular exercises help maintain mobility, strengthen supporting muscles and reduce stiffness. Perform these daily, ideally after warming your feet (warm footbath for 10 minutes).

Range-of-Motion Exercises

- Ankle circles — Sit with your foot off the floor. Slowly rotate your ankle in circles, 10 times clockwise, 10 times anticlockwise
- Toe spreads — Place your foot flat on the floor. Try to spread all toes apart, hold 5 seconds, then relax. Repeat 10 times
- Toe curls — Place a small towel on the floor. Use your toes to scrunch the towel towards you. This strengthens intrinsic foot muscles
- Alphabet writing — Lift your foot and use your big toe to "write" the alphabet in the air. This moves the ankle through its full range

Strengthening Exercises

- Calf raises — Stand holding a chair for balance. Rise onto your toes, hold 3 seconds, then slowly lower. Start with 10 repetitions and build up
- Resistance band dorsiflexion — Sit with legs extended, loop a resistance band around the ball of your foot. Pull your toes towards you against the band's resistance. 2 sets of 15
- Marble pick-ups — Place marbles on the floor and pick them up with your toes, placing them in a bowl. Excellent for toe dexterity and strength

Balance Exercises

- Single-leg stance — Stand near a wall for safety. Lift one foot and balance on the other for 30 seconds. Progress to doing this with eyes closed
 - Tandem walking — Walk heel-to-toe in a straight line, like walking on a tightrope. 10 steps forward and back
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Footwear Guide for Foot Arthritis

Choosing the right shoes is one of the most important decisions you can make for arthritic feet. Key features to look for:

- Wide, deep toe box — Allows room for swollen or deformed toes without pressure
- Firm heel counter — Supports the heel and reduces excess motion
- Cushioned sole — Absorbs impact and reduces pressure on painful joints
- Stiff or rocker sole — For big toe arthritis, a stiff-soled shoe with a rocker bottom reduces the bending required at the big toe joint during walking
- Removable insole — Allows space for custom orthotics
- Adjustable fastenings — Velcro or laces accommodate swelling that varies throughout the day
- Low heel — No more than 2.5 cm (1 inch). High heels increase forefoot pressure dramatically

Recommended UK Brands

- DB Shoes — Made in Northamptonshire, specialist extra-wide and depth footwear
 - Cosyfeet — UK company specialising in extra-roomy footwear
 - Hotter — Wide-fitting comfort shoes made in the UK
 - New Balance — Available in multiple widths with excellent cushioning
 - Skechers — Memory foam insoles and roomy fits at accessible prices
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Orthotics and Insoles



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Custom orthotics prescribed by an NHS podiatrist can redistribute pressure away from painful joints, correct biomechanical issues and significantly reduce foot pain. Ask your GP for a

podiatry referral — NHS podiatry services are free. Over-the-counter insoles (Superfeet, Scholl) can provide interim relief.

NHS Treatment Pathway

- GP — Initial assessment, X-rays, blood tests (to check for RA), referral to podiatry or orthopaedics
- Podiatry — Biomechanical assessment, custom orthotics, nail care, footwear advice
- Physiotherapy — Exercise programmes, manual therapy, ultrasound treatment
- Orthopaedics — Steroid injections, surgical options (joint fusion, joint replacement, toe correction)
- Rheumatology — If inflammatory arthritis is suspected (RA, PsA)

Don't ignore foot pain — it affects your mobility, balance and overall quality of life. Early treatment and the right footwear can make a huge difference. Our virtual assistant can help you find UK podiatry services and footwear options for your specific needs.

This article is for general information only. See your GP or podiatrist for persistent foot pain, especially if you notice swelling, redness or deformity.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about foot and ankle arthritis uk: symptoms, exercises and footwea?

Short answer: Foot and ankle arthritis symptoms vary by type but commonly include pain, stiffness, and swelling. For big toe arthritis, you might notice difficulty walking and a bony bump. Ankle arthritis often causes deep pain, stiffness in the morning, and swelling. Rheumatoid arthritis in the feet can lead to pain under the ball of the foot and toe deformities, affecting up to 90% of those with RA.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk